THE GOSPEL VAULT

Entering and Inheriting

The Kingdom of God and the Believer's Inheritance in the New Testament

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PROPOSITION

The New Testament uses "the kingdom of God" broadly for God's reign in Christ, present now and coming in fullness. Within that broad usage, "inherit the kingdom" is a narrower expression. Every believer **enters** the kingdom by grace through faith alone; to **inherit** it is to possess a share in Messiah's reign, a future reward tied to faithfulness. The Old Testament supplies the pattern, Jesus' words at the Last Supper anchor it, and the apostles apply it.

CONTENTS

I. Introduction: Why the Distinction Matters
II. The Old Testament Grammar of Kingdom and Inheritance
III. "The Kingdom of God" as a General Expression
IV. The Bare Word "Kingdom": When Context Supplies the Meaning
V. "Inherit the Kingdom": A Narrower Expression
VI. The Reformed Reading: A Respectful Engagement
VII. Application: Walking Toward the Inheritance
VIII. Conclusion

I. Introduction: Why the Distinction Matters

Few phrases in the New Testament carry more weight, or cause more anxiety, than "will not inherit the kingdom of God." Paul uses it three times alongside lists of sins (1 Corinthians 6:9–10; Galatians 5:21; Ephesians 5:5), and sincere believers have read those lists and wondered whether they were ever saved at all. Behind the anxiety is a simple question: does "inherit the kingdom" mean the same thing as "enter the kingdom"?

The answer shapes how we read the warning passages, how we understand assurance, and how we hear Jesus' promises to His disciples. If inheriting and entering are the same, then the conduct conditions attached to inheritance become conditions, or at least necessary evidences, of eternal life. If they differ, then eternal life remains the free gift Jesus promised to all who believe (John 3:16; 5:24), and the conduct conditions speak to something more: the believer's share and role in the coming kingdom.

This paper argues the second view. It traces the Old Testament background (Section II), the broad New Testament use of "the kingdom of God" (Section III), the many places where "kingdom" stands alone and context supplies its meaning, including the Last Supper (Section IV), and the narrower expression "inherit the kingdom" (Section V). Section VI sets out the Reformed reading of the same texts with the respect it deserves, noting real common ground before offering a gentle response. Section VII applies the teaching through Paul's call in Galatians 5:16–6:9 to walk by the Spirit.

The position stated here is the Free Grace position held by The Gospel Vault: eternal life is received by faith alone in Christ alone, once for all, and rewards, including a share in Christ's reign, are the subject of the New Testament's calls to faithfulness.[1]

II. The Old Testament Grammar of Kingdom and Inheritance

The exact phrase "kingdom of God" never appears in the Old Testament, but every element of the New Testament teaching does. Israel's Scriptures supply the grammar: a King, a kingdom, a promised land, a people who enter it, and a further question of who actually possesses it. The New Testament then supplies the vocabulary.

A. God's Kingship and the Promised Kingdom

The LORD reigns over all creation (Psalm 103:19; 145:13), and He ruled Israel directly as its King (Exodus 19:6; 1 Samuel 8:7). Beyond that universal reign, God promised a specific kingdom through David's line: a son whose throne would be established forever (2 Samuel 7:12–16; Isaiah 9:6–7). Daniel saw this as a kingdom God Himself would set up, one that would never be destroyed (Daniel 2:44). Dispensational writers distinguish God's universal kingdom from this mediatorial kingdom ruled through Messiah, and it is the latter that John the Baptist and Jesus announced as "at hand."[2]

B. Daniel 7: The Saints Receive and Possess the Kingdom

> *But the saints of the Highest One will receive the kingdom and possess the kingdom forever, for all ages to come.*
> **— Daniel 7:18 (NASB95)**

Daniel 7 is the clearest bridge between the Testaments. One like a Son of Man receives everlasting dominion (vv. 13–14), and then the saints receive and possess the kingdom (vv. 18, 22, 27). The Aramaic verb rendered "possess" means to take hold of something as one's own.[3] In Daniel, kingdom and reigning belong together. The saints do not merely live under Messiah's rule; they share it. That is precisely the note Jesus will sound in Luke 22:29–30.

C. Inheritance Is a Land Word

Two Hebrew words carry the theme. *Naḥălâ* is an allotted possession, the portion of land assigned to each tribe and family. *Yārash* means to take possession, often by driving out the current occupants.[4] Inheritance in Israel was concrete: fields, boundaries, vineyards, a place to live under one's own fig tree.

When the Septuagint translated these words into Greek, it regularly used *klēronomeō*, "to inherit," the same verb found in "inherit the kingdom." Jesus' beatitude "the gentle ... shall inherit the earth" (Matthew 5:5) repeats Psalm 37:11 almost word for word.[5] The New Testament vocabulary of inheritance comes straight from Israel's land promises.

D. Redeemed, Entering, Possessing

The most important Old Testament contribution is a pattern: being redeemed, entering the land, and possessing an inheritance in it are three different things.

- **Redeemed, yet not entering.** The Exodus generation was redeemed by the Passover blood and believed in the LORD at the sea (Exodus 14:31), yet that generation died in the wilderness (Numbers 14:26–35). Hebrews 3–4 applies the episode to believers.[6]
- **Entering, yet not fully possessing.** The tribes crossed the Jordan, but several failed to drive out the inhabitants and never fully took their allotments (Judges 1:21–36).
- **Inheritance granted for faithfulness.** Caleb received Hebron because he had followed the LORD fully (Numbers 14:24; Joshua 14:9–14).
- **Sonship kept, birthright lost.** Reuben remained Jacob's son but forfeited the birthright (1 Chronicles 5:1–2). Hebrews 12:16–17 draws the same lesson from Esau.

> *But My servant Caleb, because he has had a different spirit and has followed Me fully, I will bring into the land which he entered, and his descendants shall take possession of it.*
> **— Numbers 14:24 (NASB95)**

In each case the relationship is secure. Israel remains God's redeemed people; Reuben remains a son. What depends on faithfulness is the inheritance. This is the pattern the New Testament takes up.[7]

E. Where the Overlay Stops

The Old Testament pattern should not be pressed beyond what it can bear. First, the Old Testament has no "enter the kingdom" versus "inherit the kingdom" vocabulary; the pattern lives in Israel's story, and the New Testament puts it into words. Second, the Old Testament kingdom is national and land-centered, while the New Testament widens the picture to include Gentile believers, a present spiritual dimension (Colossians 1:13), and the new

creation.[8] Third, the typology is contested: Reformed interpreters read the wilderness generation as an example of unbelief rather than of believers losing reward (see Section VI). The Old Testament supports the distinction; it does not settle the debate on its own.

FOR FURTHER STUDY Deuteronomy 1:34–39 · Joshua 1:1–6 · Psalm 2:8 · Daniel 7:13–27 · Hebrews 3:7–4:11

III. "The Kingdom of God" as a General Expression

In the Gospels and Acts, "the kingdom of God" (Matthew usually says "the kingdom of heaven") is a broad, flexible expression. It names God's reign in the person of His Messiah, and context determines which aspect is in view.

A. The Kingdom Present in the King

Jesus announced that the kingdom was "at hand" (Mark 1:15) because the King Himself had arrived. When He cast out demons by the Spirit of God, the kingdom had come upon His hearers (Matthew 12:28; Luke 11:20). Wherever the King was present and His authority displayed, the kingdom was present in Him.

B. A Present Spiritual Sphere

The apostles also speak of believers already belonging to the kingdom. God has rescued us from the domain of darkness and transferred us to the kingdom of His beloved Son (Colossians 1:13). The kingdom shows itself now in righteousness, peace, and joy in the Holy Spirit (Romans 14:17), and in power rather than in talk (1 Corinthians 4:20). Every believer, without exception, has been transferred into this kingdom by God's act.

C. A Future, Literal Kingdom

Yet the kingdom is also future. After the resurrection, the disciples asked whether Jesus would now restore the kingdom to Israel (Acts 1:6); He did not correct the expectation, only its timing. Jesus promised the Twelve thrones "in the regeneration" (Matthew 19:28) and spoke of a kingdom that would come with the Son of Man's return (Luke 21:27–31). Revelation 20 describes the saints reigning with Christ for a thousand years. Dispensational theology understands this as the literal, earthly reign promised to David's Son.[9] Many dispensationalists also use the language of "already" and "not yet" for the present and future aspects of the one kingdom program.[10]

D. How People Relate to the Kingdom

Across these uses, the New Testament describes several ways people relate to the kingdom:

- They **see** it and **enter** it by new birth (John 3:3, 5).
- They **receive** it like a child (Mark 10:15).
- Believers **seek** it first (Matthew 6:33).
- Believers **proclaim** it (Luke 9:2; Acts 28:31).

> *Jesus answered, "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is born of water and the Spirit he cannot enter into the kingdom of God."*
> **— John 3:5 (NASB95)**

Notice what governs entrance. Jesus ties entering the kingdom to new birth, and new birth to believing in Him (John 3:5, 15–16). The entry language is the language of grace. No one in the New Testament is said to enter the kingdom on the basis of how well they have lived.

FOR FURTHER STUDY Matthew 13:10–17 · Luke 17:20–21 · John 3:1–18 · Acts 8:12 · Colossians 1:12–14

IV. The Bare Word "Kingdom": When Context Supplies the Meaning

Not every reference uses the full phrase "kingdom of God." Often the New Testament simply says "the kingdom," "My kingdom," "Your kingdom," or "My Father's kingdom," and the reader is expected to infer the meaning from context. These bare uses deserve attention in their own right, because several of them carry the clearest teaching on reward and reigning.

A. The Last Supper: A Kingdom Still to Come

> *But I say to you, I will not drink of this fruit of the vine from now on until that day when I drink it new with you in My Father's kingdom.*
> **— Matthew 26:29 (NASB95)**

On the night before the cross, Jesus told the Twelve He would not drink the fruit of the vine again until He drank it new with them in His Father's kingdom (Matthew 26:29; Mark 14:25). Luke records two parallel statements: He would not eat the Passover again until it was fulfilled in the kingdom of God, and He would not drink until the kingdom of God came (Luke 22:16, 18).

Two observations follow. First, even with the King present at the table, the kingdom in its fullness was still future. Whatever "at hand" meant in Jesus' early preaching, a coming of the kingdom remained ahead. Second, Jesus described that future kingdom in concrete terms: a meal, a table, a cup shared with Him. The Lord's Supper itself looks forward; Paul says believers proclaim the Lord's death until He comes (1 Corinthians 11:26).

B. Luke 22:28–30: Appointed a Kingdom

> *You are those who have stood by Me in My trials; and just as My Father has granted Me a kingdom, I grant you that you may eat and drink at My table in My kingdom, and you will sit on thrones judging the twelve tribes of Israel.*
> **— Luke 22:28–30 (NASB95)**

Immediately after the cup, and after a dispute about which disciple was greatest, Jesus addressed the Eleven as those who had stood by Him in His trials (Luke 22:28). To them He said He was granting them a kingdom, just as the Father had granted one to Him (v. 29). The verb (*diatithemai*) belongs to the same word family as "covenant" (*diathēkē*), which

Jesus had used minutes earlier of the new covenant in His blood (v. 20).[11] The kingdom is conferred by covenant.

Three features of this promise stand out. It is given to disciples described by their faithfulness: "you are those who have stood by Me." It includes table fellowship: they will eat and drink at His table in His kingdom. And it includes rule: they will sit on thrones judging the twelve tribes of Israel. This is Daniel 7 brought into the upper room. The saints receive the kingdom and share Messiah's dominion.[12]

Arguably no single text better anchors the distinction this paper defends. Jesus does not describe here how anyone enters the kingdom; that is settled by faith (John 3:16). He describes a share in ruling it, promised to those who had stood by Him.

C. Other Bare Uses of "Kingdom"

The same context-driven pattern appears throughout the New Testament:

Reference	Expression	What the context supplies
Matthew 6:10	"Your kingdom come"	A kingdom still awaited; disciples pray for its arrival.
Matthew 24:14	"this gospel of the kingdom"	A message announcing the coming reign, preached before the end.
Matthew 8:11–12	"sons of the kingdom"	Israel, the natural heirs of the promise, contrasted with Gentiles who recline with the patriarchs.
Luke 23:42	"when You come in Your kingdom"	The kingdom tied to Messiah's future arrival.
John 18:36	"My kingdom is not of this world"	The kingdom's source and character, not its location.
1 Corinthians 15:24	"hands over the kingdom"	The mediatorial reign completed and delivered to the Father.
2 Timothy 4:1, 18	"His appearing and His kingdom"	The kingdom linked to Christ's appearing.
2 Peter 1:11	"the eternal kingdom"	An entrance "abundantly supplied": degrees of welcome.

D. 2 Peter 1:11: An Entrance Richly Supplied

> *for in this way the entrance into the eternal kingdom of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ will be abundantly supplied to you.*
> **— 2 Peter 1:11 (NASB95)**

Peter urges believers to add moral excellence, knowledge, self-control, perseverance, godliness, brotherly kindness, and love to their faith (2 Peter 1:5–7). Those who do so will receive an entrance into the eternal kingdom that is abundantly supplied (v. 11). The readers already have faith (v. 1) and have been purified from their former sins (v. 9). Peter's concern is not whether they will enter, but how richly they will be welcomed. Here the New

Testament speaks openly of degrees within the kingdom, which is exactly what the inheritance language implies.[13]

FOR FURTHER STUDY Matthew 19:27–30 · Luke 19:11–27 · 1 Corinthians 11:23–26 · 2 Timothy 4:6–8, 18 · Revelation 3:21

V. "Inherit the Kingdom": A Narrower Expression

Against this broad background, the phrase "inherit the kingdom" behaves differently. It is narrower, and it follows a consistent pattern.

A. Always Future

No one in the New Testament is said to have inherited the kingdom already. Believers have been transferred into it (Colossians 1:13), but inheriting it always lies ahead (Matthew 25:34; 1 Corinthians 6:9–10; 15:50; Galatians 5:21; James 2:5).

B. Consistently Tied to Conduct or Character

Wherever "inherit" is used of the kingdom or of the believer's future portion, a condition of conduct or character is close at hand:

Text	Who inherits, or who is excluded	Condition attached
Matthew 5:5	The gentle inherit the earth	Character
Matthew 25:34–40	Those on His right inherit the kingdom	Mercy shown to "the least of these"
1 Corinthians 6:9–10	The unrighteous will not inherit (addressed to brethren, v. 8)	Practice of unrighteousness
Galatians 5:21	Those who practice the deeds of the flesh will not inherit	Practice
Ephesians 5:5	The immoral, impure, and covetous have no inheritance	Character and practice
James 2:5	Heirs of the kingdom promised to those who love Him	Love for God
Colossians 3:24	Those who serve the Lord Christ	Service, repaid as "the reward of the inheritance"
Romans 8:17	Fellow heirs with Christ	Suffering with Him
Revelation 21:7	The one who overcomes	Overcoming

The contrast with the entry language is striking. The New Testament never says anyone enters the kingdom because of how they have lived, and it rarely speaks of inheriting the kingdom without reference to how one has lived. The two expressions are not used interchangeably.

C. Linked to Reward and Reigning

> *and if children, heirs also, heirs of God and fellow heirs with Christ, if indeed we suffer with Him so that we may also be glorified with Him.*
> **— Romans 8:17 (NASB95)**

Paul says believers are heirs of God and fellow heirs with Christ, "if indeed we suffer with Him" (Romans 8:17). Free Grace interpreters see two inheritances here.[14] Every child of God is an heir of God; that follows from being a child. To be a fellow heir with Christ, sharing His inheritance of the nations (Psalm 2:8), is conditioned on suffering with Him. Paul makes the same link elsewhere: if we endure, we will also reign with Him (2 Timothy 2:12). Jesus promises authority over the nations to the one who overcomes (Revelation 2:26–27).

> *Whatever you do, do your work heartily, as for the Lord rather than for men, knowing that from the Lord you will receive the reward of the inheritance. It is the Lord Christ whom you serve.*
> **— Colossians 3:23–24 (NASB95)**

Colossians 3:24 is explicit: the inheritance is received as a reward for service. Paul writes to slaves who had little earthly inheritance to expect, and he assures them that faithful work done for Christ will be repaid with the reward of the inheritance. A reward, by definition, is not a gift received by faith alone; it answers to work done.[15]

D. The Warning Lists Addressed to Believers

The three vice lists are the texts that trouble readers most, and their context matters. In 1 Corinthians 6, Paul has just rebuked the Corinthian believers for suing one another, and then says that they themselves wrong and defraud, even their brethren (v. 8). The very next sentence asks whether they know that the unrighteous will not inherit the kingdom (v. 9). The warning is aimed at believers who were acting unrighteously. Paul is not questioning their salvation; two verses later he affirms that they were washed, sanctified, and justified (v. 11).

Read this way, the warning is serious without undermining assurance. A believer who lives like the unrighteous will not lose eternal life, which is God's irrevocable gift (John 10:28–29; Romans 11:29). But that believer forfeits a share in ruling with Christ. Galatians 5:21 and Ephesians 5:5 follow the same logic; each is addressed to churches Paul regards as genuinely saved.[16]

E. Galatians: Heirs Who Are Warned About Inheriting

Galatians shows the distinction inside a single letter. Paul tells the Galatians that all who belong to Christ are heirs according to the promise (Galatians 3:29), and that every son is an heir through God (4:7). Yet a chapter later he warns these same "brethren" (5:13) that those who practice the deeds of the flesh will not inherit the kingdom of God (5:21). He even says he is warning them in advance, as he had before. Paul does not contradict himself. Every believer is an heir of God; whether a believer inherits the kingdom in the fuller sense depends on how he walks.

Two details sharpen the point. The warning concerns those who *practice* such things: Paul uses a present participle, describing an ongoing pattern of life rather than a single failure.[17] And Paul sums up the whole section in one sentence: "If we live by the Spirit, let us also walk by the Spirit" (5:25). To *live* by the Spirit is the life every believer already has. To *walk* by the Spirit is the daily practice Paul urges, and the inheritance follows the walk. Section VII returns to this passage for application.

F. Two Texts That Need Care

1 Corinthians 15:50. Flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom of God. This verse is about bodies, not conduct. Mortal, perishable bodies must be transformed into immortal ones before anyone can take possession of the kingdom (vv. 51–54). It confirms that inheriting is future and that resurrection is its precondition.

Matthew 25:31–46. The sheep inherit the kingdom prepared for them (v. 34), and the goats depart into the eternal fire (v. 41). This is the passage where inheriting appears closest to final salvation, and honesty requires saying so. Dispensational interpreters commonly read it as a judgment of the nations at Christ's return, determining who enters the millennial kingdom in natural bodies; Free Grace writers differ on the details.[18] What can be said is that even here the inheritance is described in connection with deeds of mercy (vv. 35–40), consistent with the pattern above.

G. "Inherit Eternal Life"

A related expression, "inherit eternal life" (Matthew 19:29; Luke 10:25; 18:18), follows the same pattern. In Matthew 19:29 it is promised to those who have left houses and family for Jesus' sake, alongside receiving many times as much. Mark 10:30 places that eternal life "in the age to come" as part of a reward for sacrifice. Free Grace interpreters understand this as the abundant experience of eternal life in the kingdom, given as reward, distinct from eternal life received as a gift the moment one believes (John 5:24).[19]

FOR FURTHER STUDY Matthew 5:3–12 · Romans 8:14–18 · Galatians 4:1–7 · Hebrews 6:11–12 · James 2:5 · 1 Peter 3:9

VI. The Reformed Reading: A Respectful Engagement

Reformed theology reads these same passages with care and conviction, and its reading deserves to be stated at its strongest. Many faithful pastors and scholars hold it. The aim here is not to win an argument but to understand a brother's reading and explain, gently, why this paper reads the texts differently.

A. The Reformed Position Stated

The kingdom. Reformed theology understands the kingdom as Christ's redemptive reign, inaugurated at His first coming and consummated at His return. Geerhardus Vos and Herman Ridderbos developed this "already and not yet" framework with great depth.[20] [21] Most Reformed theologians are amillennial. They see no separate future earthly kingdom for Israel, but one people of God who will inherit the new creation.[22]

Inherit means enter. In this view, to inherit the kingdom is to receive final salvation, and every elect believer will do so. Three texts are central:

- **Galatians 3:18.** The inheritance is based on promise, not on law.
- **Ephesians 1:14.** The Holy Spirit is the pledge of our inheritance.
- **1 Peter 1:4.** Believers are born again to obtain an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, unfading, and reserved in heaven for them.

The conduct texts. The vice lists in 1 Corinthians 6, Galatians 5, and Ephesians 5 describe the kind of life that marks those who are not heirs. Because saving faith always bears fruit, a person who persists in such a life shows that he never truly believed. Thomas Schreiner and Ardel Caneday argue that the New Testament warnings are the very means God uses to preserve His people, so that they persevere to final salvation.[23]

The Old Testament patterns. Reformed interpreters read the land typologically. Abraham was promised that he would be heir of the world (Romans 4:13), and the patriarchs desired a better, heavenly country (Hebrews 11:16). The wilderness generation failed to enter because of unbelief (Hebrews 3:19), and Esau pictures one who was never truly among God's heirs.

B. Common Ground

Before noting differences, the agreement is worth stating plainly.

- **Salvation is by grace through faith, not by works** (Ephesians 2:8–9). Both traditions affirm it wholeheartedly.
- **The kingdom is both present and future.** Reformed already-and-not-yet language is shared, in substance, by many dispensationalists.
- **The Last Supper points forward.** Reformed interpreters see the cup fulfilled at the marriage supper of the Lamb (Revelation 19:9), with the Lord's Supper as a present foretaste. Both traditions hear in Jesus' words a promise of future fellowship at His table.
- **Rewards are real.** Reformed theology has long taught that believers will receive differing rewards (1 Corinthians 3:12–15; 2 Corinthians 5:10). The disagreement is not whether rewards exist, but whether "inherit the kingdom" is one of them.
- **Assurance should rest on Christ.** Sinclair Ferguson, writing in the Marrow tradition, insists that faith looks first to Christ, not to its own fruit, for assurance.[24] Free Grace readers warmly welcome that emphasis.

C. A Gentle Response

With that common ground in view, here is why this paper reads the inheritance texts differently.

Galatians 3:18 and 1 Peter 1:4. These are the strongest Reformed texts, and what they say is true of every believer. But they describe being an heir of God, the inheritance that belongs to every child because he is a child (Romans 8:17a; Galatians 4:7). Romans 8:17b, Colossians 3:24, and Luke 22:29–30 describe something added: co-heirship with Christ, a

reward, a throne. The New Testament holds both, and the distinction lets each text say what it says.

The addressees of 1 Corinthians 6. The Reformed reading must treat the warning in verse 9 as describing outsiders or false professors. But verse 8 addresses the Corinthians themselves, and verse 11 calls them washed, sanctified, and justified. The more natural reading keeps the warning addressed to the believers Paul is rebuking.

Galatians 5:24. Reformed readers note that "those who belong to Christ Jesus have crucified the flesh" and take it as a description of every true believer's conduct. Read alongside Romans 6:6–13, it more naturally states the believer's position in Christ, which is why Paul immediately adds the exhortation to walk by the Spirit (5:25). If the verse described everyone's behavior automatically, the call to walk would be unnecessary.

The Exodus generation. Hebrews 3:19 rightly says they failed through unbelief. Yet Exodus 14:31 says that same generation believed in the LORD after the sea crossing. Their failure was a failure to keep trusting God for what lay ahead, not evidence that they were never redeemed. They remained His people; they forfeited the land.

The vocabulary pattern. Most decisively, the entry language and the inheritance language behave differently throughout the New Testament (Sections III–V). If inheriting simply meant entering, it would be surprising that entrance is never conditioned on conduct while inheritance almost always is.

These responses are offered with respect. A reader persuaded by the Reformed view still shares with this paper the conviction that Christ saves by grace and that faithfulness matters. The real question is what, exactly, faithfulness gains.

Question	Reformed reading	Free Grace reading
What is the kingdom?	Christ's redemptive reign, already present, consummated in the new creation	God's reign in Christ, present spiritually now, coming as a literal messianic kingdom
Does "inherit" mean "enter"?	Yes; both describe final salvation	No; entering is by faith, inheriting is possessing and reigning
1 Corinthians 6; Galatians 5; Ephesians 5	Describe those who are not truly saved	Warn believers of losing their inheritance, not eternal life
Galatians 3:18; 1 Peter 1:4	The inheritance is final salvation, given by promise	The inheritance every child of God has; co-heirship with Christ is additional
Old Testament land and wilderness	Typology of the new creation; unbelief excluded	A redeemed people who possess or forfeit an inheritance
The Last Supper cup	Fulfilled at the marriage supper of the Lamb	Fulfilled in Messiah's kingdom, with the faithful at His table and on thrones

FOR FURTHER STUDY Romans 4:13–16 · Galatians 4:1–7 · Ephesians 1:11–14 · Hebrews 3:7–19 · 1 Peter 1:3–5

VII. Application: Walking Toward the Inheritance

If inheriting the kingdom is a reward for faithful believers, how should a believer live in light of it? Paul answers that question in Galatians 5:16–6:9. The passage was written to people who were already heirs of God, and it shows them how to walk toward the inheritance.

> *If we live by the Spirit, let us also walk by the Spirit.*
> **— Galatians 5:25 (NASB95)**

A. Start From What Is Settled

Paul's exhortations begin from a finished fact: "we live by the Spirit" (5:25). The Galatians were sons of God through faith (3:26) and heirs through God (4:7). Nothing in chapter 5 revokes that. The believer who reads the warning in 5:21 with a troubled conscience can hear it rightly. Eternal life was settled the moment he believed (John 5:24). The question before him is not whether he belongs to God's family, but how he will walk as a member of it.

B. Expect the Conflict

The flesh and the Spirit are set against each other in the believer (5:17). The struggle is not evidence that a person was never saved; it is the normal experience of a saved person who still lives in a mortal body. Paul names it so that believers will not be surprised by it, and so that they will know where victory comes from.

C. Walk by the Spirit, Step by Step

> *But I say, walk by the Spirit, and you will not carry out the desire of the flesh.*
> **— Galatians 5:16 (NASB95)**

Paul's remedy for the flesh is not the law (5:18) but the Spirit. The word he uses in 5:25 pictures keeping in step, as soldiers march in line.[25] Walking by the Spirit is daily dependence: trusting God moment by moment, yielding to His leading, and turning back quickly when we stumble. It is a walk, not a single event, and it is available to every believer.

D. Take the Warning Seriously

A distinction is not a dismissal. Those who make a practice of the deeds of the flesh will not inherit the kingdom (5:21). To lose one's inheritance is a real loss, as Esau discovered with tears (Hebrews 12:17). The warning keeps its full strength precisely because it is not reduced to a test of whether faith was genuine. It speaks to believers about what they stand to gain or forfeit.

E. Let the Fruit Grow

The fruit of the Spirit (5:22–23) describes the character of those who will share Christ's reign. One quality on Paul's list is gentleness, from the same word family Jesus used when He said the gentle will inherit the earth (Matthew 5:5).[26] The Spirit grows in believers now the very character that the kingdom will reward. Against such things, Paul adds, there is no law (5:23).

F. Restore One Another Gently

Paul expects that a believer may be caught in a trespass (6:1). The church's response is not to question that person's salvation but to restore him in a spirit of gentleness, bearing one another's burdens (6:2). Inheritance thinking makes the church a place of restoration: the goal is to help a brother back into step, so that he does not lose what he could gain.

G. Keep Sowing

> *Let us not lose heart in doing good, for in due time we will reap if we do not grow weary.*
> **— Galatians 6:9 (NASB95)**

Paul closes the section with a harvest. Whoever sows to the flesh reaps corruption; whoever sows to the Spirit reaps eternal life (6:8). This is eternal life as reward, the rich harvest of the age to come (Section V.G), and it comes "in due time" to those who do not grow weary (6:9). Jesus said the same to the Eleven: "you are those who have stood by Me." Ordinary faithfulness in trial, in service, and in suffering is remembered and rewarded with a share in His reign.

Every Lord's Supper is a reminder of this. When believers take the cup, they look back to the cross that secured their life and forward to the table in the kingdom, where the Lord Himself will drink it new with His people.

FOR REFLECTION

- Where do you feel the conflict of Galatians 5:17 most sharply right now, and what would walking by the Spirit look like in that place this week?
- Which quality of the fruit of the Spirit do you most want God to grow in you as preparation for reigning with Christ?
- Is there a brother or sister caught in a trespass whom you could gently help back into step (Galatians 6:1–2)?

VIII. Conclusion

The New Testament uses "the kingdom of God" broadly for God's reign in Christ, present now in a spiritual sense and coming in fullness when the King returns. It often uses "kingdom" alone, with context supplying the meaning, and some of those bare uses, above all the Last Supper and Luke 22:29–30, carry its clearest teaching on reward and reigning. Within that broad usage, "inherit the kingdom" is a narrower expression: always future, consistently tied to conduct, and linked to reward and co-rulership with Christ.

The Old Testament supplies the pattern: a redeemed people who enter the land, and a further question of who possesses an inheritance in it. Reformed brothers and sisters read the same texts as describing final salvation, and they do so out of a sincere concern for holiness. This paper offers a different reading out of a concern for assurance and for the full weight of Christ's promises to His faithful servants. Entrance is a gift, received by faith alone. Inheritance is a reward, and it is worth living for. Those who live by the Spirit are called to walk by the Spirit, and in due time they will reap.

Lord, thank You.

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[1]Zane C. Hodges, *Grace in Eclipse: A Study on Eternal Rewards*, 2nd ed. (Denton, TX: Grace Evangelical Society, 2007).

[2]Alva J. McClain, *The Greatness of the Kingdom: An Inductive Study of the Kingdom of God* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1959; repr., Winona Lake, IN: BMH Books, 1974). McClain distinguishes God's universal kingdom from the mediatorial kingdom exercised through a divinely chosen ruler and fulfilled in Messiah's reign.

[3]The Aramaic verbs are *qabbēl* (receive) and *ḥăsan* (take possession). See Francis Brown, S. R. Driver, and Charles A. Briggs, *A Hebrew and English Lexicon of the Old Testament* (Oxford: Clarendon, 1907), Aramaic section, s.v. חָסַן.

[4]Brown, Driver, and Briggs, *Lexicon*, s.v. נַחֲלָה (*naḥălâ*: possession, property, inheritance) and יָרַשׁ (*yārash*: take possession of, inherit, dispossess).

[5]Psalm 37:11 in the Septuagint (Psalm 36:11 LXX) reads οἱ δὲ πραεῖς κληρονομήσουσιν γῆν. Matthew 5:5 reads μακάριοι οἱ πραεῖς, ὅτι αὐτοὶ κληρονομήσουσιν τὴν γῆν.

[6]Exodus 14:31 records that after the sea crossing the people feared the LORD and believed in the LORD and in His servant Moses. For a Free Grace treatment of the wilderness generation as a redeemed people who forfeited their inheritance, see Joseph C. Dillow, *The Reign of the Servant Kings: A Study of Eternal Security and the Final Significance of Man*, 2nd ed. (Hayesville, NC: Schoettle Publishing, 2011).

[7]Dillow, *Reign of the Servant Kings*, develops the Old Testament inheritance motif at length as the background for New Testament inheritance language.

[8]Arnold G. Fruchtenbaum, *Israelology: The Missing Link in Systematic Theology*, rev. ed. (Tustin, CA: Ariel Ministries, 1993), treats the land promises and their relationship to Israel and the church.

[9]J. Dwight Pentecost, *Thy Kingdom Come: Tracing God's Kingdom Program and Covenant Promises Throughout History* (Wheaton: Victor Books, 1990).

[10]Craig A. Blaising and Darrell L. Bock, *Progressive Dispensationalism* (Wheaton: BridgePoint, 1993). Not every dispensationalist adopts their framework; the point is that already-and-not-yet language is not unique to Reformed theology.

[11]Walter Bauer, *A Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament and Other Early Christian Literature*, rev. and ed. Frederick William Danker, 3rd ed. (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2000), s.v. διατίθημι and διαθήκη. Luke 22:29 uses the verb twice: κἀγὼ διατίθεμαι ὑμῖν καθὼς διέθετό μοι ὁ πατήρ μου βασιλείαν.

[12]John A. Martin, "Luke," in *The Bible Knowledge Commentary: New Testament*, ed. John F. Walvoord and Roy B. Zuck (Wheaton: Victor Books, 1983).

[13]Robert N. Wilkin, *The Road to Reward: A Biblical Theology of Eternal Rewards* (Irving, TX: Grace Evangelical Society, 2003).

[14]Dillow, *Reign of the Servant Kings*, distinguishes the inheritance every believer has as a child of God from co-heirship with Christ, which is conditioned on faithfulness.

[15]Hodges, *Grace in Eclipse*, treats the believer's inheritance and reign with Christ as reward rather than gift.

[16]Zane C. Hodges, *The Gospel Under Siege: Faith and Works in Tension*, 2nd ed. (Dallas: Redención Viva, 1992), addresses the Pauline vice lists from a Free Grace perspective.

[17]Galatians 5:21 reads οἱ τὰ τοιαῦτα πράσσοντες, "those who practice such things," a present participle of πράσσω.

[18]Many dispensational interpreters understand Matthew 25:31–46 as the judgment of living Gentiles at Christ's return, distinct from the judgment of believers' works (2 Corinthians 5:10) and from the final judgment of Revelation 20:11–15.

[19]Wilkin, *Road to Reward*, discusses "inherit eternal life" in the Synoptic Gospels as a reward for faithful discipleship.

[20]Geerhardus Vos, *The Teaching of Jesus Concerning the Kingdom of God and the Church* (New York: American Tract Society, 1903).

[21]Herman Ridderbos, *The Coming of the Kingdom*, trans. H. de Jongste, ed. Raymond O. Zorn (Philadelphia: Presbyterian and Reformed, 1962).

[22]Anthony A. Hoekema, *The Bible and the Future* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1979), a widely read Reformed amillennial treatment.

[23]Thomas R. Schreiner and Ardel B. Caneday, *The Race Set Before Us: A Biblical Theology of Perseverance and Assurance* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2001). Schreiner and Caneday engage the Grace Evangelical Society by name.

[24]Sinclair B. Ferguson, *The Whole Christ: Legalism, Antinomianism, and Gospel Assurance—Why the Marrow Controversy Still Matters* (Wheaton: Crossway, 2016).

[25]The verb is στοιχέω (*stoicheō*), to be in line with or to follow; see Bauer, *Lexicon*, s.v. στοιχέω.

[26]Galatians 5:23 uses πραΰτης (*prautēs*, gentleness); Matthew 5:5 uses πραεῖς (*praeis*, the gentle), from the related adjective πραΰς. See Bauer, *Lexicon*, s.v. πραΰτης and πραΰς.